

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN RUSSIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide uses the Russian terms and bodies you'll actually run into — the environmental expertise (ekspertiza) and public consultation, specially protected natural areas, the prosecutor's office, the administrative courts — and explains each in plain words the first time. Safety is paramount here: keep every fight strictly local, specific, and rigorously non-political, and always check the current position.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In August 2020, on a sacred chalk hill called **Kushtau** in the republic of Bashkortostan — one of a handful of ancient reef mountains, the *shihans*, that Bashkirs hold holy — a soda company began felling forest to mine the hill for limestone. The response became one of the very few grassroots victories in modern Russian history. Word spread; people came. On 16 August, some **ten thousand people** from across Bashkortostan arrived, tore down the barricades with their bare hands, pushed past the private security and riot police, and physically occupied the hill. The standoff grew too large to crush quietly. **Moscow was forced to intervene**, the regional head was sent to negotiate, the mining was stopped, and **Kushtau was given the status of a specially protected natural monument**. A sacred mountain a company had already begun to strip was saved.

The ten thousand who saved Kushtau won a rare Russian victory with a thin but real toolkit, used with the greatest care. An **environmental review (ekspertiza)** and a **public-consultation** requirement can catch a project skipping the law. The strong protection of **specially protected natural areas** shields a place, as it now shields Kushtau. The **prosecutor's office** can be asked to enforce the law against a violator. And a peculiar geography of grievance — the big cities exporting their waste and costs to the regions — sometimes turns a local fight into one the **federal centre itself chooses to defuse**, as at the Shiyes Arctic landfill. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Kushtau was won because it was **specific** (this hill, this concrete harm), **local and broad** (a whole people, mobilised), and **rigorously non-political** (about the mountain and the water, never about the system or its leaders) — that is the shape of every real Russian community victory. But the courts generally cannot be turned against the state's own decisions; independent organising is dangerous and tightly constrained; protest is heavily policed and, in wartime, severely so; and organisers are targeted — after Kushtau, the authorities branded the movement "extremist" and imprisoned one of its leaders. A narrow, apolitical, place-specific win is possible, but the state may still move against those who led it, and in the current climate the risks are grave. So keep everything local, specific, and apolitical — and protect your people above all.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project depends on a chain: it must fit an approved plan; it must pass its **environmental review** (which requires some **public participation**); it must secure land, permits, and financing; then it is built. The strongest link is the political will of the authorities behind it — which you cannot move directly and must never attack openly. But the chain has weaker links: a project that **skipped its environmental review or its public consultation** is procedurally vulnerable; a project that harms a **specially protected natural area**, or that a large, purely local community opposes on concrete environmental grounds, can become a problem

the authorities prefer to defuse. **Find the weak link, and pull it — locally, specifically, and never politically.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you act, work out your real situation, carefully:

- **If it inflicts a concrete, visible harm on a large local community — a landfill, a poisoned river, a threatened sacred or protected place — and can be opposed on strictly local, apolitical grounds, it is genuinely, if narrowly, vulnerable.** That's the shape of Kushtau and Shiyes.
- **If it skipped its environmental review or public consultation, that procedural flaw is a real lever.**
- **If it's a state-priority project or you cannot avoid a political frame, it is very hard and very dangerous** — and safety must come first, always.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it, and both keep you safer: **use the state's own rules** — the environmental review, the consultation, protected-area status, the prosecutor — and **keep every fight local, specific, disciplined, and rigorously non-political**. That is how Kushtau was won, and how a fight stays survivable.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To find the weak link you have to see the chain — who decides, how a project moves, and who can be made to enforce the law.

Who Actually Decides

A project must fit an approved plan and pass its **environmental review (ekspertiza)** — a state assessment that, for many projects, requires **public consultation (public hearings or discussions)**. Permits come from the relevant agencies; the environmental regulator (**Rosprirodnadzor**) oversees compliance. Above the local level sits the decisive dynamic: **higher and federal authorities can override local ones**, and a grievance big enough to worry the centre can be resolved from the top, as at Kushtau. Understand that vertical line — your leverage often lies in a harm the centre would rather defuse than defend.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The plan and the review. The project must conform to plans, then pass its environmental review, which for many projects requires **public participation** — notice, hearings, a chance to comment. *Your opening — lawful and on the record:* take part, and check whether the review and consultation were genuinely and correctly done. A skipped or defective procedure is your firmest legal ground.

The permits. Agencies issue permits; the regulator oversees. *Your opening:* a project that skipped its review, breached a plan, or harms a protected area is violating the law — which you can put to the prosecutor.

Construction and operation. *Your opening:* violations, reported to the regulator and the prosecutor.

Follow the Rules and the Permissions

Dig up three things, carefully. **What review and approvals it needs and whether it has them** — a skipped environmental review, a defective consultation, a breach of a protected area is the soft spot. **Who's behind it** — so you understand the interests and, above all, the risks. **What law it breaks** — the specific procedure or protection it violates, because a strictly legal, apolitical case is the safe and effective one.

Who Can Be Made to Enforce the Law

Each is a channel — all within the state's own framework. The **environmental regulator (Rosprirodnadzor)** takes violation complaints. The **prosecutor's office (prokuratura)** can be asked to enforce the law against a project that broke procedure — one of the safer, more effective routes. **Specially protected natural area** status is a strong shield, and securing it can lock in a win, as at Kushtau. **Higher and federal authorities** can override protective locals or defuse a grievance. And a **broad, disciplined, strictly local public** is the force that makes a fight impossible to ignore.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the harm is concrete and local, whether the project broke procedure or hits a protected area, whether the grievance is big enough to worry the centre — and, always, whether people can act safely.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Risk	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Take part in the public consultation	10–30%	during review	low	On record; changes or a redo
Report violations to the regulator/prosecutor	15–40%	weeks–months	low	Enforcement; works paused
Challenge a skipped review/consultation	20–45%	months–1 yr	low–mod	Decision quashed; works halted
Win specially protected-area status	20–45%	months–yr	low–mod	Project blocked; place protected (Kushtau)
Broad, disciplined, apolitical local mobilisation	25–50%	weeks–months	high	Grievance defused from above
Everything together (concrete harm, large local public)	30–55%	months–1 yr	mod–high	Cancelled, halted, protected, delayed
Everything together (state-priority / unavoidably political)	5–20%	1–3 yr	very high	Rarely stopped; grave risk

The levers with the best record are **procedural challenges**, **protected-area status**, the **prosecutor**, and a **broad, disciplined, apolitical local public** whose grievance the centre chooses to defuse. Kushtau and Shiyes show the ceiling. The honest floor is a state-priority or politically-framed fight, which is very hard and very dangerous — and where safety must come first.

On risk: gathering documents, taking part in consultation, and complaints to the regulator and prosecutor are the lower-risk, lawful routes. Organising and protest carry serious risk — organisers have been branded "extremist" and imprisoned, and wartime repression is severe. Keep everything local, specific, and non-political; protect the vulnerable; and never let a project matter more than a person.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak, and a vague or political frame is dangerous. Being specific — this procedure skipped, this concrete harm, this protected place — is strong and safer. Answer five questions in writing, carefully.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project and the company; understand the interests and the risks.

2. Where is it, and what concrete harm does it do? Map it over your water, your air, a sacred or protected place, homes, farmland. **A specific, visible harm to a large local community — a landfill, a poisoned river, a threatened protected hill — is your strongest and safest ground**, as at Kushtau.

3. What did it need, and what's missing or defective? Did it pass its environmental review with genuine public consultation? Does it harm a protected area? A skipped review, a defective consultation, or a protected-area breach is the soft spot.

4. What law does it break? A required procedure, a protected-area rule — name it exactly. A strictly legal, apolitical case is the one the system can act on and the one that keeps you safe.

5. Who else is affected — and how broad and local is the opposition? The breadth of a strictly local public is what makes a fight impossible to ignore. Kushtau drew a whole people.

What this looks like in real life. A community learns a landfill or mine is coming that will poison its water or destroy a treasured place, with a rushed or skipped review. The five questions yield: a named project; a concrete, visible harm to a large local public (the strong, safe ground); an environmental review skipped or a consultation faked; a specific procedure broken; and a broad local opposition. That's the Kushtau pattern — build a strictly local, apolitical, legally-grounded case, and press it through the state's own channels.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can act and one that can't is proof — and a strictly legal, apolitical, well-documented case is both the most effective and the safest. Build it in three layers, carefully.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the project rests on — the environmental review, the consultation record, the approvals and permits, the plan, any protected-area designations.

Access-to-information rules give a lawful basis to request them. Then read them for flaws — a skipped or defective environmental review, a consultation that never genuinely happened, a breach of a protected area or of the approved plan.

Layer two: the ground truth. Dated, located photographs and video of the site and the threatened water, place, or homes — baseline evidence most of all — kept securely.

Layer three: the map of law and harm. Lay the project over the water, the protected or sacred place, and the homes it threatens, and against the specific procedures and protections it breaks, so the legal case and the concrete harm are undeniable. A tight, lawful, non-political dossier is what the prosecutor and the regulator can act on — and what a fight can survive on.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The environmental review, the consultation record, the approvals and permits, the plan, protected-area designations** — from the agencies and via access-to-information requests (8A).

- **The specific procedures and protections** — the review and consultation requirements, the protected-area rules the project must meet.
- **Ownership and interests** — company records, to understand who's behind it and the risks.
- **The law-and-harm map** — water, protected or sacred place, and homes, laid over the project and against the rules it breaks.
- **Dated site evidence** — photographs marked with date and place, kept securely.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a broad local public gives you weight — but in Russia, how you organise determines whether you are safe. Build carefully, in four moves.

Start with a tight, trusted core. The neighbours most affected, a few steady people, and any respected local figure — kept small and trusted.

Keep it strictly local, specific, and non-political. This is both the effective and the safe path: about this hill, this water, this landfill — never about the system or its leaders. Kushtau's discipline was its shield; the moment a fight is framed as political, it becomes far more dangerous and far less winnable.

Build breadth, carefully. A concrete local harm can unite a whole community — Kushtau drew ten thousand. Breadth is what makes a grievance the centre would rather defuse. But weigh every step for safety, because breadth also draws the authorities' attention.

Protect people above all. Organising and protest carry serious risk; organisers have been branded "extremist" and imprisoned, and wartime repression is severe. Prefer the lawful, lower-risk channels — the documents, the prosecutor, the protected-area route — over the street where you can; protect the vulnerable; avoid anything political; and never let the project matter more than a person.

STEP 4: LEGAL & OFFICIAL CHANNELS

Law and official channels are your safest levers — but use the right one, because the courts largely cannot be turned against the state's own decisions.

Take Part in the Consultation — Lawfully, On the Record

Where a project requires **public participation**, take part and put your objections — and any procedural flaws — on the record. It is lawful, low-risk, and builds the ground for a challenge or a prosecutor's complaint.

The Prosecutor and the Regulator — Enforce the Law

The safer, more effective legal route is often to ask the **prosecutor's office** and the environmental **regulator** to **enforce the law** against a project that skipped its review, faked its consultation, or breached a protected area. A procedural or protected-area violation, well documented, is something these bodies can act on — and a decision reached without the legally required public participation can, in principle, be challenged and the works halted.

Protected-Area Status — Lock In the Win

Winning **specially protected natural area** status for a threatened place is one of the strongest, most durable outcomes — it can block a project and protect the place for good, as it did at Kushtau. Where a

place has real natural or scientific value, pursuing protected status can turn a defensive fight into a permanent shield.

The Honest Limits — and Safety

Straight talk: these channels are real but limited; the courts are largely closed against the state; a state-priority project is very hard to stop; and organising and protest carry serious personal risk, severe in wartime. So use the safe, lawful tools — the consultation, the prosecutor, the regulator, protected-area status — keep everything strictly local and non-political, protect your people, and count enforced law, a quashed procedure, a protected place, delay, and a defused grievance as real wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it — safely.

A skipped step becomes a violation. Not "we don't want this" but *"the environmental review's public consultation never genuinely happened — the decision was reached unlawfully, a matter for the prosecutor."*

A protected place becomes a shield. *"This hill has recognised natural value and should be a specially protected natural area — which the mining cannot touch."*

A concrete harm becomes a broad, local case. *"This landfill will poison the water of our whole district — a specific, local harm to thousands."*

A breach becomes a prosecutor's complaint. *"This violates the law protecting this area — we ask the prosecutor to act."*

Match it to the channel — always keeping the framing strictly legal, local, and apolitical: the flaw to the consultation record and the prosecutor; the valuable place to a protected-status bid; the concrete harm to the broad local public; the breach to the regulator.

STEP 5: MEDIA & PUBLIC ATTENTION — CAREFULLY

Public attention has helped Russian communities — Kushtau and Shiyes drew the nation — but it is the highest-risk lever, so handle it with the greatest care.

Frame it strictly around the concrete local harm, never politics. The safe, effective story is "a sacred hill / our district's water, destroyed by a specific project against the law" — never a story about the system. This framing is both more likely to move the centre and far safer.

Prefer the lawful, lower-risk channels. Documents, the prosecutor, the regulator, and protected-status bids carry far less risk than public mobilisation. Weigh any public step carefully, and let the group decide together.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one false claim discredits everything and can be used against you. And protect people above the project — avoid anything political, protect the vulnerable, remember that organisers have been imprisoned, and never assume attention is safe.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Adapt these to your language and situation; keep them strictly factual, local, and non-political; keep copies; and protect anyone at risk.

8A — Access-to-information request (to the agency).

Subject: Request for the environmental review and approvals — [project].

"We, residents of [place], request the environmental review, the public-consultation record, the approvals and permits, and any protected-area designations for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the public consultation.

Subject: Objection — public consultation on [project].

"We, residents of [place], object that [project] [was not properly reviewed / its consultation did not genuinely happen / it harms a protected area / it will poison our water]. We ask that it not proceed. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — Complaint to the prosecutor's office.

Subject: Request to enforce the law — [project].

"We report that [project] at [location] [skipped its required environmental review / faked its public consultation / breaches a protected area]: [specifics]. We ask the prosecutor to investigate and enforce the law. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Complaint to the environmental regulator.

Subject: Report of a violation — [project].

"We report that [project] violates [the specific rule / protected-area protection]: [specifics]. We ask the regulator to investigate and act. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — Petition for specially protected natural area status.

Subject: Request to protect [place].

"We, residents of [place], ask that [the hill / forest / water body] at [location], which has [natural / scientific / cultural] value, be granted specially protected natural area status. [Attach evidence.]"

8F — To local self-government / a deputy.

Subject: A concrete local harm — [project].

"We, residents of [place], ask you to support us on a specific local harm: [project] threatens [our water / a protected place]: [specifics]. [Attach evidence.]"

8G — To a company (lawful, factual).

Subject: Legal concerns with [project].

"We understand your company is developing [project] at [location], which [skipped its review / breaches a protected area]. We ask you to address these concerns and comply with the law. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8H — Rallying neighbours (carefully, locally).

Subject: Protecting our [water / hill] — what we can do lawfully.

"[Project] threatens [our water / this place], against the law. At Kushtau, a whole community protected a sacred hill — by staying local, specific, and peaceful, and using the law. Let's do the same, carefully: request the documents, take part in the consultation, report the violations, seek protected status — and look after one another. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order, and safely:

1. **Nail down the project and, above all, the concrete local harm and the procedure it skipped.** That's your strongest, safest ground.
2. **Take part in the public consultation and object (8B).**
3. **Request the review and approvals (8A), and check whether the review and consultation were genuinely done.**
4. **Report the violation to the prosecutor and the regulator (8C/8D); if the place has value, seek protected status (8E).**
5. **Photograph everything, with dates and places, and keep it secure.**
6. **Keep any wider action strictly local, specific, peaceful, and non-political — and protect people first (8H).**

Even lean, those six use the state's own rules, keep the case safe, and put the lawful levers to work.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Russia's channels are thin and the field is heavily tilted, so plan for it — and stay safe.

When local authorities back the project. A grievance big enough can be defused from **above** — the peculiar city-versus-region geography sometimes turns a local fight into one the centre resolves, as at Kushtau and Shiyes. Keep it local, concrete, and apolitical, and let the breadth of local anger do the work.

When it's a state-priority or political project. It is very hard and very dangerous. Safety must come first; consider whether the fight can be survived at all.

When consultation is faked. A staged hearing is common. Document the flaw for the prosecutor — but keep the framing strictly legal.

When organisers are targeted. They are — branded "extremist," imprisoned, especially in wartime. Prefer the lawful, low-risk channels; keep everything non-political; protect the vulnerable; and never let the project matter more than a person.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Local officials and business interests protecting a destructive project is common — and the state's own oversight can sometimes be turned against it, safely, if kept strictly to the facts.

How to spot it. A regulator that won't enforce clear violations; approvals against the law; a project shielded despite documented breaches; benefits to the connected while residents carry the harm.

Who can act. The **prosecutor's office** can enforce the law against a violator. The environmental **regulator** can sanction. **Higher and federal authorities** can override protective locals. These are all within the state's framework — which is what makes using them relatively safer.

How to act safely. Document precisely and factually — the procedure broken, the non-enforcement, the harm — and keep strictly to the law and the facts, never politics or personal accusation. Route the evidence to the prosecutor and the regulator, protect anyone exposed, and keep the framing about the specific violation. This is the safe way to press a captured local decision.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, safely. The documents build your case; naming the skipped procedure and the concrete harm aims it; a trusted, broad, strictly-local public carries it; the consultation, the prosecutor, and a protected-status bid press it. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

Early on (weeks 1–6): nail down the project, the procedure it skipped, and the concrete harm; request the review and approvals; take part in the consultation; photograph the baseline; build a small, trusted core; keep everything local and non-political.

In the thick of it (weeks–months): put the procedural and protected-area violations to the prosecutor and regulator; pursue protected-area status for a valuable place; build broad, disciplined local support; weigh any public step for safety.

The long haul (months–years): carry the enforcement and protected-status efforts; keep the fight local, concrete, and apolitical; hold the line for enforced law, a quashed procedure, a protected place, delay, or a grievance defused from above — and keep your people safe throughout.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Russia can be done — a whole community saved the sacred hill of Kushtau and had it made a protected natural monument, by staying strictly local, concrete, and non-political, and by growing too broad to ignore. Hold both truths. The tools are real but thin: an environmental review and consultation a project can be caught skipping; the strong shield of protected-area status; a prosecutor who can be asked to enforce the law; and a geography of grievance the centre sometimes chooses to defuse. And the constraints are severe: courts closed against the state, dangerous and constrained organising, state-priority projects that are very hard to stop, and real risk to organisers — who at Kushtau were later branded "extremist" and imprisoned.

Here's the discipline that wins — and keeps you safe. Name the concrete local harm and the procedure the project skipped, and build a tight, strictly legal, non-political dossier. Take part in the consultation, and put the violations to the prosecutor and the regulator. Pursue protected-area status for a place worth saving. Grow a broad, disciplined, rigorously local public whose grievance the centre would rather defuse than defend — and keep every part of it apolitical, and your people protected, above all. Count enforced law, a quashed procedure, a protected place, delay, and a defused grievance as real wins. That's what Kushtau did — a specific harm, a whole community, the law, and not one word against the system. So can you — carefully, and safely.